

THE CROWN OF ASH

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Genre: Dark Fantasy

Manuscript: 112,000 words

Original Manuscript — Before Editing

The king was dead.

Everyone knew it.

His son, Rowan, was standing in the throne room looking at the crown.

He knew he had to become king.

The people outside were angry.

There were soldiers everywhere.

His adviser told him that he should put the crown on.

Rowan didn't want to.

He remembered what his father had told him.

"The crown belongs to whoever is willing to pay for it."

Rowan didn't understand what he meant.

Now he did.

There was blood on the throne.

Editing Issues

- The opening lacked a distinctive voice.
- The political conflict needed clarification.
- Rowan's emotional response was underdeveloped.
- World-building was introduced too generally.
- The crown needed symbolic significance.
- The chapter needed stronger tension.

Edited Manuscript — After Editing

The king died before dawn.

By sunrise, three armies were already marching toward the capital.

Rowan stood alone beneath the black banners of House Veyr, staring at the crown his father had worn for thirty-one years.

It was smaller than he remembered.

That surprised him.

As a child, he had imagined the crown as something enormous—golden, magnificent, impossible to lift.

Now it looked like what it truly was.

A circle of blackened metal.

A prison disguised as a symbol.

"Your Highness."

Lord Marrec stood behind him.

"Put it on."

Rowan didn't move.

Beyond the doors, thousands of voices filled the square.

Some shouted his name.

Others shouted for his death.

"How many?"

Marrec hesitated.

"How many what?"

"Soldiers."

"Enough."

Rowan turned.

"That isn't an answer."

"It is the only one that matters."

Rowan looked back at the throne.

There was blood beneath it.

Not his father's.

Someone else's.

He crouched.

A thin red line disappeared beneath the stone.

His father had once told him something strange.

The crown belongs to whoever is willing to pay for it.

Rowan had thought it was a metaphor.

Now he wasn't so sure.

A bell sounded in the distance.

Once.

Twice.

Then the palace doors exploded inward.

The guards drew their swords.

Marrec stepped forward.

"Take the crown."

Rowan looked at it.

For the first time, he understood what his father had meant.

The crown did not belong to the king.

The king belonged to the crown.